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Reading Aloud Helps Readers with Dyslexia

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Abstract

We test whether hearing a text while reading it helps adults with dyslexia. In two studies (n = 120), listening along improved comprehension by 12%, as shown in [3]. The effect held across ages and texts.

1 Introduction

Dyslexia affects reading for about one in ten people (Snowling et al., 2020; Peters, 2018a). Many readers use text-to-speech programs to keep up with long texts. Some programs mark each word as it is spoken,[1] which may help readers keep their place. Earlier work found mixed effects of such support on accuracy (Wood et al., 2018, p. 12), but few studies looked at the compre-

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Figure 1: Accuracy by condition. Bars show the mean of each group.

1 See the project page for the programs we tested and their settings.

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hension of long texts. We therefore asked whether reading along helps, e.g. in university courses, and whether the help lasts. Code and data are at https://osf.io/abc12 for anyone.

2 Method

Participants read twelve passages, half with the voice and half without (see Fig. 1). Each passage was followed by ten questions; we report the share answered correctly.

Table 1: Mean accuracy and reading time by group.

Group	Accuracy	Time	n
Dyslexic	0.81	1.2	40
Control	0.93	0.9	40

Listening along raised accuracy in both groups, and the gain was larger for readers with dyslexia than for the control group.

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3 Results

The gain held a month later. Readers said the voice helped them keep their place. A model trained on the answers, BERTBASE, agreed with the raters.

References

Peters, M. 2018a. Deep contextual word representations. In Proceedings of NAACL, pages 2227–2237.

Snowling, M. J., Hulme, C., and Nation, K. 2020. Defining and understanding dyslexia. Oxford Review of Education, 46(4):501–513.

Wood, S. G., Moxley, J. H., Tighe, E. L., and Wagner, R. K. 2018. Does use of text-to-speech and related read-aloud tools improve reading comprehension? Journal of Learning Disabilities, 51(1):73–84.

Appendix A. Passages

The twelve passages came from first-year textbooks, four from each of three subjects.

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